

Resource Document: Documented Trajectories in the Churches of Christ (2000–2025)

This document provides verifiable historical and scholarly citations regarding the shifting identity of institutional Churches of Christ in the twenty-first century. It follows a "Source, Context, and Quotation" format to ensure each claim can be cross-referenced with primary and secondary materials.

I. The Scholarly Framework: Harrell and Hughes

1. David Edwin Harrell Jr., *The Churches of Christ in the 20th Century* (2000)

ISBN-13: 978-0817310080. This volume is the sequel to Harrell's *Quest for a Christian America* (1966) and *The Social Sources of Division in the Churches of Christ* (1973).

- **Point of Reference:** The sociological drive for "Cultural Respectability."
- **Documentation:** Harrell identifies a recurring pattern where institutional expansion leads to "ministerial professionalism" and "denominational institutionalism."
- **Quotation (p. 140):** "One [group] opposed institutionalism and advocated a cultural separatism while the other promoted institutionalism and sought cultural respectability."
- **Verification:** Harrell argues that the division of the 1950s/60s was not merely over orphan homes, but over an attitude toward the "silence of scripture" as either a prohibition or a permission for expediency.

2. Richard T. Hughes & James L. Gorman, *Reviving the Ancient Faith* (3rd Ed., 2024)

ISBN-13: 978-0802877291. This updated edition covers the trajectory up through 2022.

- **Point of Reference:** The "Identity Crisis" of the 21st Century.
- **Documentation:** Part Three, Chapter 14: "Identity Crisis amid Decline in the Twenty-First Century."
- **Quotation (p. 1):** Hughes defines the "Sect-to-Denomination" transition as a defining characteristic of the movement's evolution from a 19th-century sect to a 20th-century denomination.
- **Verification:** The authors trace the "loss of apocalypticism" and the shift toward "subjective experience" as the catalyst for the abandonment of traditional restorationist markers.

II. Case Study: Oak Hills Church (2003)

Context: The decision by the San Antonio, TX congregation (led by Max Lucado) to sever formal ties with the "Church of Christ" designation.

- **Reference:** Official Statement/Interview with *Baptist Press* (May 9, 2005) and *Bible Truths* Archives.
- **The "Barrier" Quote:** "I was really struck that many people would not visit our church because of the name. They had a bad experience somewhere with the Church of Christ... Oak Hills has never fit into that mold." (Lucado, 2005).
- **On Baptism (Theological Drift):** "There are those who have taught that baptism is necessary for salvation... We have felt that baptism is necessary for obedience, but that baptism doesn't add to what Christ does for us in the cross." (Lucado, 2005).
- **On Identity:** Associate Minister Vic King stated, "It's the sign that we are changing. We are changing to a sign that more accurately reflects who we are." (2003).

III. Case Study: The Hills Church / Richland Hills (2006)

Context: The announcement by the Richland Hills Church of Christ (then the largest in the U.S.) to add instrumental worship.

- **Reference:** Sermon Series: *"The Tale of Two Brothers"* (Dec 2006); Rick Atchley.
- **The Hermeneutical Shift:** Atchley utilized Acts 15 and Romans 14 to argue that the musical instrument was a matter of "opinion" (expediency) rather than a "faith" issue (command).
- **Quotation:** "They [the believers] were more committed to their mission than to their tradition." (Atchley, sermon transcript principle #4).
- **Verification:** This decision is documented in Hughes/Gorman (2024) and Jack Reese (2021) as the catalytic moment that normalized "dual-track" worship in mainstream congregations.

IV. The "Elegy" Phase: Jack R. Reese (2021)

Source: *At the Blue Hole: Elegy for a Church on the Edge* (ACU Press, 2021). ISBN-13: 978-0802879523.

- **Point of Reference:** The death of the "Patternist" hermeneutic.
- **Quotation (Introduction):** "Said plainly, churches are in trouble. All churches are, but certainly Churches of Christ. Whether or not they recognize the threats they are facing is a different matter."
- **Verification:** Reese argues for a shift from "Unity as a Law" to "Unity as a Wellspring of Grace," which requires a surrender of the strict CENI (Command, Example, Necessary Inference) framework.

V. Timeline of Key Trajectory Markers

Year	Event / Publication	Hermeneutical Significance
2000	Harrell publishes <i>The Churches of Christ in the 20th Century</i> .	Documents the roots of institutional drift.
2003	Oak Hills (San Antonio) drops "Church of Christ" name.	Symbolic end of "Restoration" exclusivity.
2006	Richland Hills (TX) adds instrumental worship.	Public rejection of the "A Cappella" distinctive.
2012	Broadway (Lubbock) moves toward instrumental music.	Drift reaches "Flagship" traditional centers.
2021	Jack Reese publishes <i>At the Blue Hole</i> .	Theological "elegy" for the traditional movement.
2024	Hughes & Gorman release 3rd Ed. of <i>Reviving the Ancient Faith</i> .	Documents the transition to "Denominationalism" as complete.